

Session 15: Commissioning the Nation

Key Takeaways

- At Sinai, God redefines Israel's identity.
- As God's *segullah*, or "treasured possession," Israel is being called to fulfill a special purpose in representing God to the nations.
- Peter calls the New Testament Church, made up of Jewish and Gentile followers of Jesus, God's *segullah*.

Key Terms for the Sinai Narratives

- Theophany: the visible manifestation of God's presence
- Covenant: a formal, permanent agreement between two parties
- Decalogue: the Ten Commandments
- Stipulations: the requirements of the covenant to which both parties agree
- Ratification: the official ritual by which a covenant takes effect
- Tabernacle: the authorized place of God's holy presence (tent)
- Priesthood: the official tabernacle service by authorized men from Levi
- Ordination: the official ritual in which someone becomes a priest
- Consecrate: set apart, make holy
- Cult: the entire system of worship (tabernacle, priests, sacrifices)

Exodus 19:4-6 NIV

⁴ "You yourselves have seen what I did to Egypt, and how I carried you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself. ⁵ Now if you obey me fully and keep my covenant, then out of all nations you will be my **treasured possession**. Although the whole earth is mine, ⁶ you will be for me a **kingdom of priests** and a **holy nation**." These are the words you are to speak to the Israelites.

What Does It Mean To Be God's Treasured Possession?

The Hebrew word *segullah*, often translated "treasured possession," is used in two primary ways. Concretely, it refers to the personal treasury of a king (1 Chron. 29:3 and Ec. 2:8). Metaphorically, *segullah* is used to identify a covenant partner with special responsibility to represent the sovereign (Exod. 19:5; Deut. 7:6, 14:2, 26:18; Ps. 135:4; Mal. 3:17).

Related words in Ugaritic (*sgl*) and Akkadian (*sikiltu*) are also used in these two ways.

Who Is YHWH's Treasured Possession?

Usually, Israel is the treasured possession because of the Sinai covenant (Exod. 19:5; Deut. 7:6, 14:2, 26:18; Ps. 135:4). But Malachi 3:17 envisions a future day in which YHWH will select a new *segullah*.

That new acquisition prompted Greek translators to choose a slightly different phrase. *περιούσιος* becomes *περιποίησις*.

1 Peter 2:9-10 NIV

⁹ But you are a chosen people, a **royal priesthood**, a **holy nation**, God's **special possession** (*περιποίησις*), that you may declare the praises of him who called you out of darkness into his wonderful light. ¹⁰ Once you were not a people, but now you are the people of God; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.

Peter applies covenant titles from Sinai to a mixed audience of Jews and Gentiles. He sees the Church as the fulfillment of Malachi 3:17—God's acquisition of a new *segullah*.

Reflection Question

How does God redefine the identity of the Israelites in Exodus 19:3-6?